



J3C-65 Cub



PA-12 Super Cruiser



PA-28 Cherokee



PA-46 Malibu Meridian

- 1928** William T. Piper joins the Taylor Brothers Aircraft Company as an investor.
1930 Piper buys the assets of the company. Gilbert Taylor remains as chief engineer.
1931 The Taylor E2 Cub is certified.
1935 Piper buys out Taylor.
1937 The business relocates to Lock Haven, Pennsylvania, and changes its name to Piper Aircraft Corporation. The Piper Cub is launched.
1941 The Piper YO-59, renamed the L-4, goes into service with the US Army.

- 1946** Record year in which 7,782 aircraft are built and Piper opens a second plant at Ponca City, Oklahoma. The PA-12 Super Cruiser is launched.
1947 Sales collapse, Piper Aircraft Corporation defaults on a loan, and Bill Piper loses control of the company.
1950 Bill Piper regains control of the Piper Aircraft Corporation.
1959 The 50,000th aircraft is built and the PA-25 Pawnee plane used for agriculture enters production.

- 1960** The PA-28 Cherokee, Piper's most numerous and successful type, is introduced. A new plant is opened at Vero Beach, Florida.
1969 Piper Aircraft Corporation sales top \$100 million. Bill Piper retires.
1970 Bill Piper dies at the age of 89.
1984 Lear Siegler Corporation effectively acquires Piper, aircraft sales slump because of the cost of liability insurance, and two plants are closed.
1987 Piper is sold to M. Stuart Miller.

- 1990** Production halts as the company slips into bankruptcy.
1995 New Piper Aircraft Inc. is launched.
2000 The turboprop version of the PA-46, the Malibu Meridian, is delivered.
2003 American Capital Strategies Ltd. (ACAS) takes 94 percent of New Piper equity.
2004 Hurricane damage stops production at Vero Beach for several months.
2009 ACAS sells Piper Aircraft to the investment strategy company Imprimis.
2011 Work on the PiperSport craft is halted.



Flying on Cub wings

The PA-25 Pawnee was designed to replace the converted training aircraft used for crop dusting. It featured Super Cub wings mounted low on a fuselage that included a safety cage of tubes surrounding the pilot.

“Anyone who **hurts himself** in one of these things **ought to have his head examined.**”

WILLIAM T. PIPER ON THE CUB

undercarriage PA-24 Comanche and the PA-30 and PA-39 Twin Comanche (Piper was by now giving its aircraft North American Indian names). However, the old “rag-and-tube”

Tri-Pacer was losing out to Cessna's more modern all-metal 172 by the end of the 1950s. Piper responded in 1960 with the PA-28 Cherokee, an all-metal, low-wing, fixed-

undercarriage machine that was designed for economical manufacture and launched a hugely successful line of aircraft that continues to this day.

Despite hostile takeover bids, board battles, and floods at its famed Lock Haven plant, Piper thrived during the 1960s and late 70s and its model range expanded. Production hit a peak of 5,250 in 1978–79, before product liability insurance costs grew to the point that they very nearly killed off the whole US light aircraft industry in the mid-1980s.

While today Piper is unlikely to see production levels hit those of its glory years, the company survived bankruptcy in the early 1990s and hurricane damage to its Vero Beach factory in 2004, and continues to make fine aircraft today.

Bill Piper stepped down as company chairman in 1969. He died in January 1970, but the little airplane with which he will forever be associated lived on as a Piper product until 1994, when the final PA-18 Super Cub was rolled off the production line.